

HALF NOTE SOLOING

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #172

There is no better way to learn to solo over a song, or to get deeper into a song you think you already know, than Half Note Soloing. Simply improvising with ONLY half notes. This is actually challenging rhythmically for many novice and intermediate players, and is melodically and harmonically challenging for ALL players, including grad students and full time pros. Give it a try - this is some incredibly powerful practice, when done right.

#1 - Mostly "3rds and 7ths" (What Is This Thing Called Love)

Exercise #1 is a half-note soloing exercise over the first four measures of the song "What Is This Thing Called Love". The key signature has one sharp (F#), and the time signature is 4/4. The exercise consists of two staves of music. The first staff contains the first three measures, and the second staff contains the fourth measure. The notes are half notes. The chords for each measure are: Gø7, C7(b9), Fm6, and Dø7. The notes in the first staff are: G4, A4, B4, C5 (Gø7); D5, E5, F#5, G5 (C7(b9)); A5, B5, C6, B5 (Fm6); and A5, G5, F#5, E5 (Dø7). The notes in the second staff are: D5, C5, B4, A4 (Dø7); G4, F#4, E4, D4 (G7(b9)); C4, B3, A3, G3 (Cmaj7); and F#3, E3, D3, C3 (Cmaj7). A bracket under the last two measures of the second staff is labeled "a few passing notes".

Once you can consistently hit chord tones, and especially 3rds and 7ths on all the chords (#1 above), it's time to begin thinking melodically, adding tensions, releases, passing notes and wider intervals (#2, below). Like with brain surgery and sky diving, it's easier to read about than to actually do. Invest some time practicing this, with *every* song you play!

#2 - Tension Notes, and 1/2 step resolutions

Exercise #2 is a half-note soloing exercise over the first four measures of the song "What Is This Thing Called Love". The key signature has one sharp (F#), and the time signature is 4/4. The exercise consists of two staves of music. The first staff contains the first three measures, and the second staff contains the fourth measure. The notes are half notes. The chords for each measure are: Gø7, C7(b9), Fm7, and Dø7. The notes in the first staff are: G4, A4, B4, C5 (Gø7); D5, E5, F#5, G5 (C7(b9)); A5, B5, C6, B5 (Fm7); and A5, G5, F#5, E5 (Dø7). The notes in the second staff are: D5, C5, B4, A4 (Dø7); G4, F#4, E4, D4 (G7(b9)); C4, B3, A3, G3 (Cmaj7); and F#3, E3, D3, C3 (Cmaj7). Brackets under the notes in the first staff indicate 1/2 step resolutions: G4 to A4, B4 to C5, D5 to E5, F#5 to G5, and A5 to G5. Brackets under the notes in the second staff indicate 1/2 step resolutions: D5 to C5, C5 to B4, B4 to A4, A4 to G4, G4 to F#4, F#4 to E4, E4 to D4, and D4 to C4.